

The Khmer Rouge

During the first two years of the Nixon administration, a combination of US actions and political intrigue in Phnom Penh helped to mold Cambodia's radical communist faction into a dangerous threat to both Cambodia and to American interests.

◀◀ BEFORE

Historical antagonism between Cambodians and Vietnamese inhibited fraternal relations between the communist movements in each country.

HANOI AND SIHANOUK

Vietnamese leaders had dominated the Indochinese Communist Party created by Ho Chi Minh in the 1930s. When a small group of **communist-led rebels** formed in Cambodia in the 1950s to oppose Sihanouk, they received little help from the Vietnamese communists. The Politburo in Hanoi saw a neutral Cambodia as an advantage. It made an **arrangement with Sihanouk** to allow it to resupply and rest its troops in Cambodia in return for not aiding Sihanouk's enemies.



BAS RELIEF OF KHMER SOLDIERS FROM ANGKOR WAT

In 1963, the general secretary of the Communist Party of Kampuchea (CPK) was a shadowy figure named Saloth Sar. A leading figure in the resistance to French rule in Cambodia, he later became committed to the overthrow of the government of Prince Norodom Sihanouk, who steered a neutral line in foreign policy.

Under Sar's leadership, the CPK was transformed into the extreme and violent movement that became the Khmer Rouge. Sar—known as Brother Number One—assumed the name Pol Pot.

Although the communists of North Vietnam initially supported the Khmer Rouge, by the mid-1960s, this alliance had broken down. The pact between Sihanouk and the Vietnamese communists led the Khmer Rouge to hate both in equal measure.

Although versed in the ideologies of the French revolution, Marxism, and Stalinism, Pol Pot believed that Cambodia had nothing to learn from external influences and envisioned the restoration of the old glory of the Khmer Kingdom. He and his followers viewed all Vietnamese people—from the North or South—as enemies.

The Forest Army